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Witchcraft, oracles and magic among the Azande

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In the second case it is fairly clear what may have happened. Magic was made to kill or frighten away the witch who was spoiling Dereakowe's hunting, and his wife fell violently sick. In these circumstances it is not surprising that she and others saw some connexion between the two events. But even if she drew attention to the causal relationship between the making of magic and her own illness, it does not follow that she admitted that she was a witch, though others might readily have given her remark this interpretation. Notions about Zande magic and the way it works are very intricate and allow of varied private judgements. It is possible that no witch was in fact acting against Dereakowe's hunting, and that he had neglected to consult the oracles before making magic, or that some one had broken the taboos of magic, and in either of these cases the magic might easily have turned on one of the inmates of the homestead.

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The case of Wöndo is of particular interest. It is incredible that he could really have made the remarks attributed to him, but it is of importance to note that Azande found it easy to believe that he had made them. It seems necessary for maintenance of belief in witchcraft that there shall be occasional confessions, either real or supposed. The treatment of Wöndo illustrates what I have written earlier, that so long as a witch refrains from murder and is not very sensitive he will not suffer for his reputation. He is not subject to social ostracism and may even enjoy a measure of respect for his powers. Wöndo seems to have fared well enough.

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The manner in which anything that a suspected witch may say is interpreted in a different sense from the one he intended to give to his words is shown in the case of an old man, called Bagbeyo, whom I used to meet sometimes in Rikita's province. Everybody told me that he was a witch, and the number of hens' wings he received seemed to be regarded as a big joke. When I asked him why he was always accused of witchcraft he replied that it was because he possessed powerful magic to protect his gardens. When people came to injure his crops with their witchcraft the magic killed them, and then his neighbours  133 said that he was responsible for their deaths, whereas their own witchcraft was the cause. I was surprised to learn that my companions regarded this reply as a clear confession of guilt. He could not say, 'Yes, what you say is true, I am a witch,' but he said the same thing in other words when he said, 'My magic kills people' for what he meant was 'My witchcraft kills people'. Zande doctrines are so numerous, varied, and plastic that a man can always find in them an element to serve his interests in any given situation. He does not deny the doctrines, but he selects from them what is most to his advantage in each situation and excludes the rest.

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